OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

# Shoalhaven Council asked to explain costs behind Infrastructure Plan cuts

Sent 5 August 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council, Mayor White · Response requested by 26 August 2026

**An Open Letter to the Mayor and Chief Executive Officer of Shoalhaven City Council**

Dear Mayor White and Mr Constance,

Shoalhaven City Council has now received the results of its Community Infrastructure Strategic Plan (CISP) consultation.

Over a one-month exhibition period, 2,456 people took the time to participate. Together they provided 29,292 individual responses to the proposals before them. That is one of the most significant pieces of community engagement undertaken by this Council in recent years.

Where recommendations involved the loss of facilities or services, the community's message was clear. Across the divestment and decommissioning proposals, respondents opposed the recommendations by approximately 55 per cent to 34 per cent.

Consultation has now concluded. The community has spoken. Before Council considers its final position, there are a number of questions that deserve clear public answers.

Accordingly, I ask that you address the following.

What is the estimated sale value of the 37 proposed divestment candidates, and what is the estimated annual operating saving from the 40 proposed decommissioning recommendations? Why were neither of these figures included in the public exhibition material?

What is the total estimated capital cost of the proposed new builds and master-plan recommendations, and how does that compare with the savings expected from the divestment and decommissioning program?

The report recommends that Council "investigate future land management options as appropriate." What does this phrase mean in practical terms, and which, if any, of the 43 reserves assessed are considered potential candidates for future sale?

Will Council publish the utilisation data that underpins the recommendations affecting the Callala Bay Progress Hall, Milton Tennis Club and Erowal Bay Public Hall so the community can assess the evidence for itself?

How was seasonal population and visitor demand incorporated into the benchmarking methodology that concluded there is an over-provision of facilities in Shoalhaven Heads, Callala Bay and Vincentia? What weighting was applied?

**Three public information sessions were attended by 118 people. On what basis were the comments, concerns and feedback provided during those sessions not formally recorded and included in the consultation record?**

**Is any recommendation capable of being withdrawn solely because of community opposition? If so, what level or threshold of opposition would lead Council to reconsider or abandon a proposal?**

**Does the proposed master plan for Bernie Davis Reserve encompass the same land identified in the associated divestment study, or are these separate parcels? If separate, will Council identify the land proposed for each process?**

**IPART concluded that Shoalhaven City Council remained financially unsustainable even after approving the full 12 per cent Special Rate Variation. In that context, what proportion of Council's reported $25–35 million annual structural deficit is expected to be addressed by the Community Infrastructure Strategic Plan contraction program?**

**These are not rhetorical questions. They go to the heart of informed public participation.**

**The community cannot meaningfully judge whether these recommendations are necessary unless it understands the financial assumptions, evidence and strategic reasoning that underpin them.**

**Two thousand four hundred and fifty-six people gave this Council a month of their time. They provided 29,292 considered responses. On the recommendations that would take something away from their communities, they said noby a margin of 55 to 34.**

**The question now is not whether they were heard. The consultation report demonstrates that they were.**

**The question is whether, in the Council chamber, being heard changes anything at all.**

**Yours faithfully,**

**Stephen Prothero**
**Editor**
**Eye on Shoalhaven Council**

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